PIA2050 Comparative Politics and Societies — Week 3 Summary: Identity and Inter-Group Conflict

1. Week Overview

Keywords: political development, engine of history, microfoundations, collective action, identity, recognition

- Lecture (Slide 1): *Identity and Inter-Group Conflict*, CityU PIA, Sem A 2026/27.
- Chain of argument:
    - Recap the three traditions of comparative politics (Slides 2–5).
    - Define political development as change over time (Slides 6–8).
    - Search for the "engine" of history: Kant → Hegel → Marx (Slides 9–13).
    - Build the course framework on individual-level mechanisms (Slides 14–16).
    - Solve the collective action problem with motives beyond self-interest (Slides 17–22).
    - Conclude that inter-group conflict, often a struggle for recognition, drives political development (Slides 23–25).
    - Use Social Identity Theory to explain when such struggles erupt and why they are intractable (Slides 26–28).
- One-liner: **groupish, status-seeking humans form identity groups; groups clash over recognition; those clashes drive political change.** (memorise)

2. Recap: The Three Traditions

Keywords: Lichbach & Zuckerman, structuralist, culturalist, rationalist, inevitability, agency

- Last week: Lichbach & Zuckerman 1997 on the three main approaches — **structuralist, culturalist, rationalist** (Slide 2). Know each as nutshell → strength → weakness.

2.1 Structuralists (Slide 3)

Keywords: material conditions, relations of production, class structure, constraints

- **Nutshell:** a country's social and political organisation is determined by material conditions — relations of production, class structure/inequality, technologies; systems change through **structural change**.
- **Strength:** history is made in circumstances **beyond the control of any individual**, who face crucial **constraints** in prevailing structures.
- **Weakness:** underestimates **individual agency**; overstates the **"inevitability"** of outcomes.
- → Structure explains the constraints, not the choices made within them.

2.2 Culturalists (Slide 4)

Keywords: culture, norms, logic of appropriateness, fitting in, no mechanism of change

- **Nutshell:** a country's social and political organisation is determined by its culture, which shapes the rules/norms of politics and beliefs about authority and institutions; systems change through **cultural change**.
- **Strength:** the logic of appropriateness — behaviour motivated by the desire to **"fit in"** — explains much individual behaviour.
- **Weakness:** understates **intentionality**; overstates **inevitability**; **no mechanism for cultural change = no mechanism for social and political change** (memorise).

2.3 Rationalists (Slide 5)

Keywords: self-interest, political entrepreneurs, collective action problem, unrealistic assumptions

- **Nutshell:** a country's social and political organisation is determined by individuals pursuing their self-interest.
- Outcomes hinge on whether and how leaders of organised groups ("political entrepreneurs") solve the collective action problem.
- **Strength:** focus on **individual agency** and **intentionality**.
- **Weakness: incomplete view of motivations**; **unrealistic assumptions** about how people form beliefs and decide.
- → Two traditions overstate inevitability; the third over-simplifies the individual. This week's framework keeps agency but fixes the psychology.

3. Defining Political Development

Keywords: progress, change, Human Development Index, Huntington, Fukuyama, institutions, decay

3.1 Development as Progress (Slides 6–7)

Keywords: potential realised, economic development, UNDP, HDI, rule of law

- "Development" has **at least two meanings** (Slide 6).
- **(1) As progress:** the process by which something becomes more advanced, or its potential is realised in some way.
    - "Economic development" = a poor, non-industrialised country becoming wealthy, industrialised, technologically advanced.
    - *Example:* UNDP's Human Development Index, built from **per capita income, life expectancy, and education**.
- Slide 7 quotation: **"A government of laws, and not men"** — John Adams, *Novanglus Papers, No. 7*: the classic image of political "progress" toward impersonal rule of law.
- → This meaning is normative: it presumes a better end-state.

3.2 Development as Change — The Class Definition (Slide 8)

Keywords: change over time, any direction, emerge, evolve, decay

- **(2) As change:** change over time, **in any direction** — the definition the class adopts.
- Political development is the process by which political systems change over time (memorise).
- Close to Huntington 1965 and Fukuyama 2014, both focused almost entirely on **institutions**. Fukuyama 2014 (pp. 7, 23): "change over time in political institutions" and "the process by which institutions emerge, evolve, and eventually decay".
- → **Decay counts as development too.** One-liner: *development = change, not progress.*

4. A Universal History? The "Engine" of History

Keywords: universal history, German idealism, Kant, Hegel, dialectic, consciousness, Marx, historical materialism

- Question (Slide 9): is there a **basic mechanism of political development** — an "engine" of history?
- Traced to attempts to write a Universal History of Mankind; in *The End of History and the Last Man*, Fukuyama 1992 credits **"the German idealist tradition"** with the earliest efforts.

4.1 Kant (Slide 10)

Keywords: 1784, cosmopolitan point of view, republican government

- Kant 1784, "An Idea for a Universal History from a Cosmopolitan Point of View".
- Asked "whether, when taking all societies and all times into account, there was overall reason to expect general human progress in the direction of **republican government**" (Fukuyama 1992: 58).
- But **stopped short** of writing a Universal History (p. 59). → Kant supplies the question, not the mechanism.

4.2 Hegel: The Dialectic and Consciousness (Slides 11–12)

Keywords: conflict, revolution, war, internal contradictions, forms of consciousness, idealism

- Progress arises **not from the steady development of reason** but from "the blind interplay that led men to **conflict, revolution, and war**" (Fukuyama 1992: 60).
- The dialectic: systems of thought and political systems collide and fall apart from their own internal contradictions, are replaced by less contradictory, higher ones, which give rise to new contradictions.
    - Cycle: system → contradictions → conflict/collapse → higher system → new contradictions.

- History is "not only a succession of different civilizations and levels of material accomplishment, but more importantly a succession of different **forms of consciousness**" (p. 62).
- Consciousness — the way humans think about right and wrong, the activities they find satisfying, their beliefs about the gods, even how they perceive the world — has changed fundamentally over time.
- → Hegel's engine is **idealist** and **conflict-driven** — the idea the week returns to in Section 7.

4.3 Marx: Historical Materialism (Slide 13)

Keywords: materialist dialectic, means of production, surplus, overproduction

- Karl Marx: perhaps the **most famous** Universal History. Historical materialism keeps Hegel's dialectic — systems evolve through conflict exposing contradictions that cause collapse and replacement.
- Replaces **idealism** with **materialism**:
    - Conflict is over **control of the means of production** and **appropriation of economic surplus**.
    - Contradictions are rooted in **material conditions**. *Example:* **crises of overproduction**.
- → Same engine, different fuel: **ideas** (Hegel) vs **material interests** (Marx). Fukuyama later adds **recognition** (7.3).

5. Our Framework: Building on Individuals

Keywords: microfoundations, instrumental rationality, emotions, visceral factors, beliefs, desires, Elster

- Slide 14: section divider, "Our Framework". Slide 15 restates last week's "alternative" approach as three principles.

5.1 Microfoundations and Bounded Rationality (Slide 15)

Keywords: aggregate result, realistic assumptions, emotions, visceral cravings, cost-sensitive

- **(1)** All collective behaviour is the **aggregate result of individual actions/decisions**. Explanations need realistic assumptions and "microfoundations" — mechanisms operating at the level of the individuals involved (memorise).
- **(2)** People often do not follow instrumental rationality:
    - **Emotions** can crowd out other considerations such as self-interest.
    - Even resistible impulses — **visceral cravings** — can block deliberation.
    - **Most behaviour is partly visceral but still sensitive to costs and benefits.** (memorise)

5.2 Beliefs, Motives and Elster's Template (Slide 16)

Keywords: intentional behaviour, desires, beliefs, causes, aggregation

- **(3)** Intentional, goal-oriented behaviour is explained by uncovering agents' **motivations and beliefs**.
- Elster 2007: any social-science explanation takes two steps:
  - **(i) Why individuals behave as they do — desires** (what one wants), **beliefs** (esp. about others' behaviour and the effects of one's actions), and **their causes** (possibly **structure/culture**).
  - **(ii) How individual actions combine** to produce the outcome.
- → Structure and culture re-enter as **causes of desires and beliefs**, not direct causes of outcomes.

6. Politics, Collective Action and Identity

Keywords: organised groups, Olson, emotions, self-image, moral agents, self-categorisation, parochial altruism

6.1 Politics as Group Competition (Slide 17)

Keywords: collective actors, power, resources, competing visions, group formation

- Politics is largely the competition between organised, collective actors over the distribution of power and material resources, or competing visions of how society should work.
- So we must understand how groups are **constituted**, their **internal functioning**, and their **interactions**.
- Older assumption: organisations arise whenever many people share an interest. Olson 1965, *The Logic of Collective Action*, **challenged** this but **gave no satisfactory solution**.
- Standard context: the collective action problem — people sharing an interest in a public good are tempted to free ride, so the good may never be provided.

6.2 Motive 1 — Emotions and Self-Image (Slide 18)

Keywords: anger, resentment, fear, guilt, shame, self-worth, fitting in, differentiation

- **Emotions** (anger, resentment, fear, guilt, shame) are impulses to act with **less regard for consequences**.
- More importantly, people care about **self-image and public image**: they seek reassurance of **self-worth and social standing** by **"fitting in"** (esp. with groups central to their identity) or, in other situations, by **differentiating** themselves.
- Result: thinking that is not very rational; action that **contradicts or disregards self-interest**.
- *Example:* joining a risky protest because staying home would feel shameful in front of one's community.

6.3 Motives 2 and 3 — Moral Agency and Groupishness (Slide 19)

Keywords: Beetham, common interest, promises, self-categorisation, parochial altruism

- **Moral agents:** Beetham 1991 — humans have "some notion of the common interest, and acknowledge the binding force of promises they have made"; they do what they think is right even against self-interest. Caveat: **not always a good thing**.
- "Self-categorization" — thinking of ourselves and others in terms of group membership.
- "Parochial altruism" — favouring people, even unknown people, seen as members of the same group, while discriminating against others.
- Linked to Social Identity Theory (lecture video, Slide 19).
- → Three motives (memorise): **emotions/self-image, moral agency, self-categorisation + parochial altruism**.

6.4 Sacrifice, Savagery and the Hive Switch (Slide 20)

Keywords: altruism–aggression link, perceived threat, manipulation, Haidt, 90% chimp 10% bee

- Parochial altruism plus concern for self-image/reputation makes us capable of **great sacrifice** for "our" group and **great savagery** against perceived external threats.
- Perceived interests and threats **can be manipulated**; the altruism–aggression link is well known (video).
- Haidt 2012's Hive Switch: people are **"90% Chimp, 10% Bee"**:
    - Most of life = petty individual concerns.
    - Under some conditions we "lose ourselves in something larger" — the self disappears, **collective interests dominate**.
    - Daily, we are "nagged" by a sense of a higher, nobler collective purpose.
- → The psychology of in-group heroism is the psychology of out-group cruelty.

6.5 Morality Binds and Blinds (Slide 21)

Keywords: moral narratives, political teams, rationalisation, beneffectance

- Categorisation and parochial altruism shape **beliefs** as much as motivations.
- Haidt 2012 (p. xxxiii): "People bind themselves into political teams that share moral narratives. Once they accept a particular narrative, they become blind to alternative moral worlds."
- Morality binds and blinds: moral beliefs sustain group cohesion but drive our perception of reality, blind us to **disconfirming evidence and logic**, and produce **snap judgments** we then rationalise.
- Rationalisation is self-deceiving but protects "beneffectance" — the notion that "I am nice and in control" (Pinker 1999: 423).
- *Example:* partisans condemning a scandal by the other party while excusing the same act by their own.

6.6 Endogenous Preferences and Collective Identity (Slide 22)

Keywords: endogenous, exogenous, rhetoric, narratives, symbols, rituals, dignity

- **Key point:** desires and beliefs are partly "endogenous" to mobilisation — shaped by what leaders/organisations do to maximise participation (memorise).
- Recruits hold pre-existing "exogenous" desires and beliefs — having external causes; group **rhetoric, narratives, symbols, rituals** reshape them and change predisposition to act.
- Social or collective identities are sources of solidarities, values, and self-images whose affirmation can motivate action: "this is **who I am**"; "to defend my **dignity**"; "to earn the **recognition** I/we deserve".
- → The answer to Olson: leaders solve collective action by **shaping identity, emotion and belief**.

7. Inter-Group Conflict as the Engine of History

Keywords: groupishness, status-seeking, intersubjective recognition, Fukuyama, non-materialist dialectic, dignity

7.1 Two Roots in Human Nature (Slide 23)

Keywords: social categorisation, group markers, self-evaluation, status-seeking, evolutionary basis

- Inter-group conflict is the engine of political development/history (memorise), rooted in two traits:
- **(i) Groupishness:** social categorisation to define our place; strong emotional attachment to groups; **markers** signalling affiliation; social identities used for **self-evaluation**; parochial altruism.
- **(ii) Status-seeking:** desires for subjective well-being, control of one's social environment, self-esteem, and others' approval — all with an **evolutionary basis**.
- → Groupishness defines **who "we" are**; status-seeking makes us care **where we rank**.

7.2 The Struggle for Recognition (Slide 24)

Keywords: equal or superior status, laws and policies, recognition defined

- Hence conflict often becomes a struggle for intersubjective recognition: groups seek to have others recognise their status as **equal (or superior)**; concretely, to **change how laws/policies treat groups** according to status.
- Fukuyama 1992 gives these struggles a crucial role in history; recognition is "an intersubjective state of mind by which one human being acknowledges the worth or status of another human being, or of that human being's gods, customs, and beliefs" (memorise). Fukuyama video, from 9:50.
- *Example:* civil-rights movements demanding equal legal treatment for a group previously treated as inferior.

7.3 A Non-Materialist Dialectic (Slide 25)

Keywords: centerpiece, richer than Marx, pride, identities, markers of dignity

- Fukuyama 1992: 144–5 — recognition is "the centerpiece" of a non-materialist historical dialectic "much richer in its understanding of human motivation than the Marxist version".
- **Why richer:** captures "the prideful and assertive side of human nature that is responsible for driving most wars and political conflicts"; allows conflict driven by **ideas** and especially **identities**.
- Fukuyama 2011: 41 — much contemporary politics revolves around **demands for recognition** by groups with historical reasons to feel their worth unacknowledged; demands may have an economic component, but **economic resources are often "markers of dignity rather than ends in themselves"** (memorise).
- → Lineage: Hegel (ideas) → Marx (material conditions) → Fukuyama (**recognition/identity**).

8. Social Identity Theory

Keywords: Tajfel & Turner, cognitive alternatives, legitimacy, rising expectations, zero-sum, loss aversion, threatened egotism

- Social Identity Theory (Tajfel & Turner 1986), standard context: people draw self-esteem from group membership and seek positive distinctiveness through inter-group comparison.

8.1 When Challenges Happen: Cognitive Alternatives (Slide 26)

Keywords: hierarchy, inequality, unstable, illegitimate, objective deprivation, consensual status system

- **Hierarchy and inequality** create the *potential* for recognition struggles.
- Subordinates can challenge only if they can imagine "cognitive alternatives" to the status quo.
- Challenges grow likelier when the situation becomes **unstable and illegitimate** — sometimes after an **actual decrease in "objective deprivation"**.
- Conflict is avoided only with a **"consensually accepted status system"** or one **"sufficiently firm and pervasive to prevent the creation of cognitive alternatives"** (Tajfel & Turner 1986: 12).
- → Counter-intuitive: **improvement can trigger revolt**; unquestioned hierarchy can be stable.

8.2 Rising Expectations and Zero-Sum Status (Slide 27)

Keywords: inter-group comparison, getting begets wanting, intractability, relational value

- Comparisons become **more plausible as group differences shrink**.

- The revolution of rising expectations fits motivation theory's "general rule": **"getting begets wanting"**.
- *Example:* a group gains partial rights and education, starts comparing itself with the dominant group, and demands full equality.
- Once started, recognition struggles are **especially intractable** — identity conflicts are nastier and harder to solve.
- Why: status has **relational value** (its worth depends on others' status), so the struggle is **zero-sum** — "one person's recognition can come only at the expense of the dignity of someone else" (Fukuyama 2011: 41).
- → Unlike money, status cannot be split to leave both sides better off (memorise).

8.3 Dominant-Group Backlash and Threatened Egotism (Slide 28)

Keywords: loss aversion, status quo, intense discrimination, Baumeister, evil

- People value and fear **losses far more than equivalent gains** (loss aversion), so dominant groups' preference for the status quo should be **more intense** than subordinates' preference for change.
- Challenged groups often "react in an intensely discriminatory fashion" and **redouble** defence of the status quo (Tajfel & Turner 1986: 22).
- Baumeister 1996, *Evil*: some of the worst violence stems from threatened egotism — violence in reaction to a threat, generally from below, against the self-image of someone with a high (not low) opinion of him-/herself.
- → Onset needs imaginable alternatives; intensity comes from the **proud whose status is slipping**.
- One-liner: *recognition struggles start when the subordinate can imagine change, and turn ugly when the dominant fear losing status.*

9. References (Slides 29–30)

Keywords: author–work pairs, exam citations

- Baumeister 1996 *Evil* → threatened egotism. Beetham 1991 *The Legitimation of Power* → moral agents. Elster 2007 *Explaining Social Behavior* → desires/beliefs template.
- Fukuyama 1992 *The End of History and the Last Man* → recognition. Fukuyama 2011 *The Origins of Political Order* → zero-sum status, dignity markers. Fukuyama 2014 *Political Order and Political Decay* → development as institutional change.
- Haidt 2012 *The Righteous Mind* → binds and blinds, Hive Switch. Huntington 1965 "Political Development and Political Decay" → institutional definition. Lichbach & Zuckerman 1997 → three traditions.
- Olson 1965 *The Logic of Collective Action*. Pinker 1999 *How the Mind Works* → beneffectance. Tajfel & Turner 1986 "The Social Identity Theory of Inter-Group Behavior".

10. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: last-minute recap, traditions, development, dialectic, framework, recognition, Social Identity Theory

1. **Three traditions** (Lichbach & Zuckerman 1997): structuralist (material conditions; constraints vs ignores agency) / culturalist (culture; logic of appropriateness vs no mechanism of change) / rationalist (self-interest, political entrepreneurs; agency vs unrealistic motives) (Slides 2–5).
2. **Development** as progress (HDI; "a government of laws, and not men") vs as change; class definition = how political systems change over time, incl. decay (Huntington 1965, Fukuyama 2014) (Slides 6–8).
3. **Universal history:** Kant asks the question; Hegel's idealist dialectic — conflict and contradictions, succession of forms of consciousness; Marx's materialist dialectic — means of production, surplus, overproduction (Slides 9–13).
4. **Framework:** microfoundations; emotions limit instrumental rationality but behaviour stays cost-sensitive; Elster 2007 — explain desires and beliefs (and causes), then aggregation (Slides 14–16).
5. **Politics** = competition between organised groups; Olson 1965 exposed the collective action problem without solving it (Slide 17).
6. **Motives beyond self-interest:** emotions and self-image; moral agency (Beetham 1991); self-categorisation and parochial altruism (Slides 18–19).
7. **Parochial altruism** → sacrifice for the in-group, savagery toward threats; Hive Switch, "90% Chimp, 10% Bee"; morality binds and blinds; beneffectance (Pinker 1999) (Slides 20–21).
8. **Endogenous preferences:** rhetoric, narratives, symbols, rituals reshape desires and beliefs; identity motivates via "who I am", dignity, recognition (Slide 22).
9. **Engine of history = inter-group conflict**, rooted in groupishness and status-seeking; often a struggle for recognition; economic resources as markers of dignity (Fukuyama 1992, Fukuyama 2011) (Slides 23–25).
10. **Social Identity Theory** (Tajfel & Turner 1986): challenge needs cognitive alternatives, likelier when unstable/illegitimate; getting begets wanting; status is zero-sum; loss aversion and threatened egotism (Baumeister 1996) make dominant-group backlash fierce (Slides 26–28).